

LASER PRINTERS

Laser printers have evolved over the past few years; they are more compact and manageable, and less expensive. The ability to produce fast, smudge-free prints has always been their selling point over inkjets. In 2007, we saw laser printers have achieved a level of efficiency that lets them output paper at a speed very close to the claimed speeds.

Once confined only to offices, thanks to the ever-dropping prices, the laser printer has come a long way towards finally gaining acceptance from SoHos and even at homes. The advantages that they have over inkjets are apparent—they are fast, they produce clean and sharp prints, they require little maintenance and are generally more rugged.

Also, their cost per page is remarkably lower than inkjets. With even some colour laser printers appearing in compact sizes, there is really not much to hold you back from getting one of these rather than an inkjet and this is what we predict is the shape of things to come.

PERSONAL LASER PRINTERS

The Reigning Champion HP LaserJet 1020

The vertical profile design of this printer means it occupies less desk space. It weighs just 5 kg—light. It has a 234 MHz processor and just 2 MB RAM, though that did not seem to slow it down much. The retractable input paper trays fold back into the body and can hold up to 150 sheets, sufficient for any SoHo. There is also a manual feeding tray for the occasional quick printout.

The printer cartridge is easily accessible by popping open the printer's top panel. The control panel is very easy to use. The printer supports USB 2.0, and the cable is provided. Print speed is around 14 ppm, just 1 less than the claimed 15.

The Contender Xerox 3117

The Xerox 3117 is an entry-level desktop laser printer coming at a great price. Like the HP 1020, it too is very compact and has a vertical profile design. The build quality of this creamy-white printer is simply superb. It achieves a printing speed of 15 ppm, just 2 short of the claimed 17. The print quality was good in the text as well as graphics and there was no smudging anywhere. Though it is no printer



extraordinaire, the incredibly low price of just Rs 4,500 makes it the cheapest on this planet!

The Award HP LaserJet 1020

The HP LaserJet 1020 takes just 9 seconds to print a normal text document. Text print quality was marginally better than that of most other printers. It was the best printer in the



photo document printing test, reproducing greater details in the dark areas, something the competition couldn't manage. Finer details and highlights were reproduced perfectly, too.

Good printing speeds, impressive print quality, and decent pricing go into taking this printer ahead of the rest; in addition, the unmatched warranty, easy availability of consumables, as well as good service and affordable toner prices fetch this printer the Zero1 award in this category.

LCD MONITORS

22-INCH MONITORS

The Reigning Champion None currently!

We've included a 22-inch category for our readers just because 22-inchers now seem to be *de facto* for mid-range consumers. In fact, based on the popularity of this category, we've decided to include it as a new category in our tests.

The Contenders ViewSonic VX2235WM; ViewSonic VX2255WM; Dell E228WFP; BenQ FP222W; Acer AL2216W; Samsung 226BW

Many and varied: ViewSonic's VX2235wm and VX2255wm, Dell's E228WFP, BenQ's FP222W, Acer's AL2216W, Samsung's 226BW. All these are TN panel-based LCDs.

The Award Dell E228WFP

It was a closely-fought battle. Dell's E228WFP is an excellent panel with great colour and contrast once it's properly calibrated. The only issue we see is availability. BenQ's FP222W is another excellent multimedia performer with nearly as good colour rendition as the E228WFP, the only minus is its a little bulky. The VX2235WM is good, but we didn't like its performance in some of the colour tests, and the bezel is too large.



We had a good time thrashing these monitors for all we were worth—Dell's E228WFP is available for as low as Rs 16,000, and it's a brilliant buy—great colours and great contrast at a great price. It edges out the two ViewSonics and the BenQ FP222W for the Zero1 Award.

LCDs have evolved from an emerging upstart to a mature technology. We're seeing panel costs falling, courtesy cheaper and better TN panels entering the market. The costlier PVA and S-IPS panels are also becoming cheaper, albeit at a snail's pace. We've seen 17-inch monitors being phased out in lieu of 19-inch panels at the same prices. 22-inch monitors are threatening the status quo.

19-INCH MONITORS

The Reigning Champion AOC 197S

The AOC 197S bagged our *Best Buy Gold* award for its sterling value with decent performance. Although based on a TN panel the 197S impressed with decent colour rendition in DisplayMate, and good overall contrast. Although its not the equal of an S-IPS panel or an MVA panel as far as both these parameters go it also costs a fraction for what these panels cost.

The Contender HP W1907; Dell E198WFP

The HP W1907 was another brilliant monitor—very good colour and contrast for a TN panel. The Dell E198WFP is yet another beauty—a good looking widescreen, and one of the best colour renditions we've seen for a "mere" TN panel. In fact, this monitor is very suited for image editing professionals and multimedia aficionados alike. Aesthetically the E198WFP has a beautiful stand, and a very narrow bezel—ideal for a dual monitor setup.

The Award Dell E198WFP

Dell's E198WFP really cleans up here—colour brilliance is not really associated with TN panels, but this one proves an exception in more ways than one. Definitely Zero1 material—which is why we're awarding it. HP's W1907 is also an excellent monitor but it just isn't the price league of the Dell—besides being a great performer it's a great steal at the price as well.

